

Buddhist Women in Nepal Practice Kung Fu for Self-Defense, Strength

Buddhist nuns in Nepal are once again performing martial arts for the public after a five-year break caused by the COVID-19 pandemic.

The women recently put on a show for onlookers at their religious community, called a monastery, outside the capital Kathmandu. The performance was attended by reporters from Reuters news agency.

Members of the hilltop Druk Amitabha Monastery are part of the 1,000-year-old Drukpa religious organization. The group gives nuns equal status to male community members called monks.

The Drukpa lineage includes the only female order in the male-led Buddhist monastery system. The nun community was established in 2009 and now has 300 members between the ages of six and 54.

Kung Fu nuns, who practice the martial art for self-defense and meditation, demonstrate their skills at Druk Amitabha Mountain Nunnery in Kathmandu, Nepal December 30, 2024.

The nuns come from Bhutan, India and Nepal. They are all trained in kung fu, the ancient Chinese style martial art that promotes self-defense and strength.

In their recent performance, the nuns were seen moving their hands quickly and kicking their legs high, with some holding swords. Hundreds of people gathered to watch the performance and cheered the group on.

Usually, such religious organizations expect nuns to cook and clean and not practice any form of martial arts. But one monk, Gyalwang Drukpa, decided to train women in kung fu to improve their health and spiritual well-being. He has a position just slightly below the Dalai Lama in the Tibetan Buddhist leadership.

A Kung Fu nun prepares to demonstrate her skills at Druk Amitabha Mountain Nunnery in Kathmandu, Nepal December 30, 2024.

Jigme Jangchub Chosdon is a 23-year-old nun who came from Ladakh in India. She told Reuters, "We do kung fu to keep ourselves mentally and physically fit, and our aim is to promote women's empowerment and gender equality."

A Kung Fu nun practises as she waits for her performance at Druk Amitabha Mountain Nunnery in Kathmandu, Nepal December 30, 2024.

Another performer was 24-year-old Jigme Yangchen Gamo, a nun from Ramechhap in Nepal. She said, "With the confidence from kung fu, I really want to help the community, young girls to build their own strength."

The nuns' website explains that the combination of gender equality, physical strength and respect for all living things represents the order's return to its "true spiritual roots."

In the past, the nuns have traveled long distances on foot and by bike in the Himalayas to raise money for disaster relief and to promote environment-friendly living.

A Kung Fu nun practices before her performance at Druk Amitabha Mountain Nunnery in Kathmandu, Nepal December 30, 2024.

Another member of the group is Jigme Konchok Lhamo, a 30-year-old nun from India. She said her main goal for the future is to reach enlightenment like Lord Buddha, who founded Buddhism 2,600 years ago.

She added, "But for now as I am a normal person... I think I will be focusing more on helping others. Helping others is our religion."

I'm Jill Robbins.

Gopal Sharma reported this story for Reuters. Jill Robbins adapted it for Learning English.

Vocabulary

nun - n. แม่ชี (ผู้หญิงที่เป็นสมาชิกของชุมชนทางศาสนา)

order - n. คณะสงฆ์/คณะนักบวช (องค์กรทางศาสนาที่สมาชิกมักจะอาศัยอยู่ร่วมกันและปฏิบัติตามกฎและประเพณีพิเศษ)

confidence - n. ความมั่นใจ (ความรู้สึกหรือความเชื่อว่าคุณสามารถทำบางสิ่งได้ดีหรือประสบความสำเร็จในบางสิ่ง)

enlightenment - n. การตรัสรู้ (ในศาสนาพุทธ: สภาวะทางจิตวิญญาณขั้นสุดท้ายที่ปราศจากความปรารถนาหรือความทุกข์)

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What was the primary reason for the five-year break in public martial arts performances by the Buddhist nuns in Nepal?

- A) Lack of public interest
- B) Funding issues

- C) The COVID-19 pandemic
- D) Relocation of the monastery

2. Where did the nuns' recent performance take place?

- A) Inside the capital Kathmandu
- B) At a public park in Kathmandu
- C) At their monastery outside Kathmandu
- D) In a remote mountain village

3. The Druk Amitabha Monastery is associated with which ancient religious organization?

- A) Tibetan Buddhist Council
- B) Drukpa religious organization
- C) Himalayan Meditation Society
- D) Kathmandu Spiritual Alliance

4. What distinctive characteristic does the Drukpa religious organization demonstrate regarding its male and female members?

- A) It assigns nuns to different monasteries than monks.
- B) It gives nuns equal status to male monks.
- C) It restricts nuns from leadership roles.
- D) It requires monks to train nuns in martial arts.

5. When was the specific female order, which is part of the Drukpa lineage, established?

- A) 1000 years ago
- B) In 2009
- C) Five years ago
- D) After the COVID-19 pandemic

6. What is the current approximate number of members in the nun community and their age range?

- A) 100 members, ages 18-60
- B) 200 members, ages 10-50
- C) 300 members, ages six to 54
- D) 500 members, ages 12-70

7. From which countries do the 'Kung Fu nuns' primarily originate?

- A) China, Tibet, and Nepal

- B) Bhutan, India, and Nepal
- C) Thailand, Vietnam, and India
- D) Mongolia, Nepal, and China

8. What is Kung Fu described as in the article regarding its benefits?

- A) A way to earn money for the monastery
- B) A form of entertainment for tourists
- C) An ancient Chinese style martial art that promotes self-defense and strength
- D) A competitive sport for international tournaments

9. Which of the following describes the nuns' actions during their recent performance?

- A) They performed slow, graceful movements with flowers.
- B) They used long staffs and chanted quietly.
- C) They moved their hands quickly, kicked high, and some held swords.
- D) They engaged in wrestling matches with monks.

10. In traditional religious organizations, what are nuns typically expected to do, rather than practice martial arts?

- A) Teach spiritual lessons
- B) Engage in political activism
- C) Cook and clean
- D) Travel widely

11. Who was the specific monk credited with the decision to train women in kung fu, and what was his motivation?

- A) Dalai Lama, for religious diplomacy
- B) Gyalwang Drukpa, for their health and spiritual well-being
- C) Jigme Jangchub Chosdon, for promoting tourism
- D) A local abbot, for self-defense against bandits

12. According to Jigme Jangchub Chosdon, what are the two main aims of the nuns practicing kung fu?

- A) To attract more visitors and gain fame.
- B) To keep mentally and physically fit, and to promote women's empowerment and gender equality.
- C) To prepare for combat and expand their territory.
- D) To preserve ancient traditions and meditate in silence.

13. What aspiration does Jigme Yangchen Gamo express regarding the confidence she gained from kung fu?

- A) To become a martial arts master.
- B) To travel the world.
- C) To help the community and young girls build their own strength.
- D) To establish a new monastery.

14. Based on the nuns' website, what does the combination of gender equality, physical strength, and respect for all living things signify for their order?

- A) A modern interpretation of Buddhist teachings
- B) A departure from traditional monastic life
- C) The order's return to its "true spiritual roots"
- D) A strategy to recruit new members

15. In addition to their martial arts practice, what other activities have the nuns previously undertaken in the Himalayas?

- A) Organizing international peace conferences
- B) Raising money for disaster relief and promoting environment-friendly living
- C) Building new temples and shrines
- D) Writing scholarly texts on Buddhism